

A gay couple from Romania would like to get legally married. Unfortunately, this isn't possible in Romania. What do you think: Is this okay under EU law? Tip: Check out the Charter of Fundamental Rights in envelope 1 ;-).

Solution 1: Yes, under EU law, it is permissible for same-sex marriage not to be possible in Romania. According to Article 9 of the Charter of Fundamental Rights (right to marry and right to found a family), regulations concerning marriage and family fall within the competence of the Member States. This is where the principle of conferred powers applies (Art. 5(1) TEU/Treaty of Lisbon). This principle states that the EU may only act in areas for which the Member States have conferred powers upon it. But there is a solution for your friends: The European Court of Justice has ruled that EU countries must recognize same-sex marriages if they were legally entered into in another EU country. So your friends could, for example, get married in Germany 😊.

The Council of the European Union is set to adopt an EU-wide tax on rainwater. Italy wants to prevent this. Discuss whether Italy can block the proposal.

Open to the solution in envelope 2. First, pick three people who'd like to perform a short radio play!

Characters:

- Narrator
- A Minister of Sweden
- A Minister of Denmark

Solution 2: Yes, Italy could block the proposal! Most EU laws can be adopted by a qualified majority in the Council. However, under Article 192 TFEU/Treaty of Lisbon, unanimity is required in particularly sensitive areas—mostly where member states wish to protect their core competencies. This applies, for example, to taxation, foreign policy, membership, or central government structures. So, we're in luck: rainwater remains free for now 😊.

Open envelope 3 and read aloud the fictional newspaper article inside.

Solution 3: No! This would contradict the European Water Framework Directive 2000/60/EC. The directive aims to achieve "good ecological status" for European waters and to protect people from transboundary water pollution. The directive is part of what is known as secondary legislation, which is derived from the EU Treaties (primary legislation). With regard to transboundary rivers such as the Moselle, the so-called principle of subsidiarity (Art. 5(3) TEU) applies. It states that the EU may only take action if an objective cannot be sufficiently achieved at the level of the Member States. This applies in the present case: differing national regulations would lead to inconsistent water protection, thereby preventing the objective of protecting water bodies from being effectively achieved. European regulations are therefore necessary. Conclusion: You can continue to safely cool your feet in the Moselle River this summer. Incidentally, environmental policy is a matter of shared competence within the EU. In practical terms, this means that both the EU and the member states are authorized to enact laws in this area.

Spain has been hit by severe flooding.

Discussion: Does Spain have to deal with the situation on its own? If you're not sure, open [envelope 4](#) and look up Article 222 of the TFEU.

Solution 4: No, Spain is not alone! Article 222 of the TFEU contains the so-called solidarity clause: the Union and its Member States shall act jointly if a Member State is affected by a major disaster or a terrorist attack. In such cases, the EU can provide financial support. Germany also benefited from this in 2021 following the flooding disaster in the Ahr Valley, receiving funds from the European Union's Solidarity Fund to help address the extensive damage more quickly. This is a true example of solidarity: all EU member states collectively bear the financial burden of a disaster that has hit a single country particularly hard.

Take a look at the pictures in [envelope 5](#). Do you have any idea what these pictures have in common?

Solution 5: Oulu in Finland and Trenčín in Slovakia are the European Capitals of Culture for 2026. For 40 years, the "European Capital of Culture" title has offered cities the opportunity to celebrate diversity, engage communities, and promote local and regional development. This funding enables the organization of cultural events, exhibitions, and performances that highlight the richness of Europe's shared cultures. The legal basis for this is Article 167 of the TFEU, which grants the EU the authority to promote and complement the cultures of the Member States. Cultural policy falls under the EU's so-called supporting, coordinating, and complementary competences. Incidentally, Oulu's 2026 motto is "Cultural Climate Change" and addresses current global challenges. Trenčín has chosen "Curiosity" as the theme for its program. The city aims to build bridges between people, the past and the future, as well as between imagination and reality.

During a get-together with friends, a heated discussion breaks out about healthy eating. The discussion is sparked by a newspaper article about overweight children. The conversation turns to the question of whether a healthy diet is a human right.

You decide to launch a European Citizens' Initiative.

Open [envelope 6](#) and put the necessary steps in the correct order.

Solution 6: The European Citizens' Initiative is one of several forms of citizen participation within the EU. A European Citizens' Initiative on the topic of healthy eating is currently underway: "GOOD FOOD 4ALL." The initiative states its mission as follows: "Food is a human right for everyone!" "The EU must systematically guarantee the right to food and promote healthy, equitable, humane, and sustainable food systems for current and future generations."

Time for a mystery! Imagine the following fictional scenario titled “Tampered Food in European Supermarkets”:

Identical protein bars are being sold in several EU countries—including Germany, France, and Belgium. A few days later, doctors and hospitals report an increase in severe cases of food poisoning. Investigations are launched at all levels, and it quickly becomes clear:

A criminal group infiltrated the supply chain and tampered with the products in illegally rented warehouses. Their goal was to extort money from a major food company by threatening to release more tampered food products.

Before that happens, the network will be uncovered and shut down.

The European agency Europol played a key role in the investigation.

Open envelope 7!

Solution 7: Europol is an EU agency that coordinates and supports police cooperation among EU member states. It is established under Article 88 of the Treaty on the Functioning of the European Union (TFEU). Unlike a national police force, which has its own patrols, Europol focuses on coordination and analysis. In this case, Europol's approach might have looked like this:

1 □. Cross-border pattern recognition: As the first cases emerge, the affected countries report them to Europol. Europol identifies a cross-border pattern.

2. Integration of intelligence and investigative data, e.g., by cross-referencing supply chains, monitoring cross-border transport movements, or analyzing encrypted chat groups.

3. Establishment of a joint investigation team with the affected countries.

Through cooperation between Europol and national authorities, the network can be identified before more products enter circulation. Without coordination at the EU level, the cases would initially have appeared to be isolated, national food poisoning incidents. However, thanks to rapid coordination, the perpetrators were arrested simultaneously in several countries by national authorities, and the dangerous products were removed from store shelves.